



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE
Policy and Standard Operating Procedures on the Management of Major Crime Scene

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1.0 Introduction

The initial actions taken by patrol and investigating officers at crime scenes will often determine the course and success of an investigation. The first officer attending the scene plays a crucial role by rendering emergency services, initiating the investigation and protecting the crime scene.

2.0 Purpose

The purpose of this policy and standard operating procedures is to provide members of the JCF with guidelines for responding to and dealing effectively with the operational demands at major crime scenes.

3.0 Scope

This policy and standard operating procedure shall apply to all members of the JCF and its auxiliary. It is established to guide personnel in initial assessment and efficient investigation, preservation, communication and collection of evidence at major crime scenes.

4.0 Abbreviations and Acronyms

CAP	Common Approach Path
CCU	Corporate Communication Unit
DDI	Divisional Detective Inspector
ESLA	Electrostatic Lifting Apparatus
FCSM	Forensic Crime Scene Manager
FCSI	Forensic Crime Scene Investigator
IFSLM	Institute of Forensic Science and Legal Medicine
IO	Investigating Officer
RO	Responding Officer
RVP	Rendezvous Point
SOC3	Crime scene checklists
SOC1	Crime Scene Log
SOCO	Scene of Crime Officer

5.0 Definitions

5.1 1st Responding Officer (RO)
First officer on the crime scene.

5.2 Common Approach Path (CAP)
This is the only path that in use to access the scene. This is established from the outer cordon through to the scene. When establishing CAP personnel must avoid the likely route used by the perpetrator/suspect.

5.3 Crime Scene Log
This log records all activities/ access on the scene which should be maintained whenever possible outside the inner cordon area and used to record details of all persons, police and other agencies as well as vehicles entering the inner cordon. It must be completed in chronological order and each entry will include the day, date and time of persons entering, departing and the reason for their attendance.

5.4 Exhibit Receipt
A receipt containing the full description of exhibit, day, date and time of exhibit handed over at the Forensic Laboratory, this receipt also bears the signature of the person who received the exhibit.

5.5 Inner Cordon Area
An erected barricade using tape, rope, etc., around the area where the crime has been committed in order to secure and restrict access to the scene.

5.6 Outer Cordon Area

An erected barricade using tape, rope, etc., beyond the inner cordon to be used for security and administrative purposes.

5.7 Rendezvous Point (RVP)

This is an area/section that is established at the outer cordon, and its location communicated to control. All persons entering the crime scene must report at this point.

5.8 SOC/FSCI Report (SOC 2 & 2A)

Form consisting of information regarding the; investigating officer, victim(s), suspect(s)/accused, and a checklist of the exhibits collected from the scene, along with a narrative of the investigators report.

6.0 Responsibilities

The following summarizes key responsibilities:

- 6.1** The Assistant Commissioner of Police i/c Crime has overall management and oversight responsibility for the effective functioning of Scenes of Crimes
- 6.2** The Commanding officer of the Technical Services Division (TSD) is responsible for ensuring strict compliance with the Crime Scene Policy and SOP
- 6.3** The Officer i/c Scenes of Crime Department has responsibility for coordinating the activities of Scene of Crime Units across the island

7.0 Policy Statement

It is the policy of the JCF that all major crime scenes will be effectively managed to preserve and maintain the integrity of all exhibits and evidence in the investigation process.

8.0 Standard Operating Procedures

The management and coordination of all major crime scenes will be treated according to the following guidelines and procedures:

8.1 In responding to the Scene

When responding to a crime scene, members shall:

- 8.1.1** acknowledge receipt of assignment by informing PECC and Supervisor;
- 8.1.2** be cognizant of suspects and/or vehicles that may be in flight. A decision to arrest or pursue the perpetrator should be made based on weighing the needs of the victim(s) and others against the safety of the public if the perpetrator were allowed to escape;
- 8.1.3** adhere to the rules of the Road Code and policies relating to the use of the siren and hot pursuit; and
- 8.1.4** notify PECC and Supervisor upon arrival.

8.2 Assess the Crime Scene

On arrival at the scene, the 1st RO shall:

- 8.2.1** assess the situation while considering personal safety;
- 8.2.2** take the necessary steps to protect victim(s) and/or others;
- 8.2.3** administer first aid and/or summon emergency medical assistance if required;
- 8.2.4** arrest perpetrator(s) if at scene;

8.2.5 request backup assistance if necessary to restrict access to the crime scene, and to control onlookers; and

8.2.6 update PECC and Supervisor

8.3 Preserve the Crime Scene

In order to preserve the crime scene, the 1st RO shall identify the extent of the scene to be included within its boundaries:

8.3.1 Inner Cordon

8.3.1.1 all areas that may be reasonably searched for evidence;

8.3.1.2 entry and exit routes used by the suspected perpetrator;

8.3.1.3 erect barricade tape, rope, etc. in order to secure the crime scene; and

8.3.1.4 only authorized personnel are permitted to enter the inner cordon, after reporting to the RO or Scene Control Officer.

8.3.2 Outer Cordon

i. restricted area beyond the inner cordon designated for security and administrative purposes; and

ii. marked using tape.

8.3.3 Commence a Crime Scene Log (SOC1)

Using the designated form, commence a crime scene log with the following considerations. The Log:

i. must be kept outside the inner cordon;

ii. should be completed in chronological order. This must include date, time, name of persons entering and departing, the name of their respective agencies, reasons for entering, along with the particulars of their vehicles;

iii. must be maintained until the scene is released and then submitted to the investigating Officer, along with the RO or Scene Control Officer's statement; and

iv. must be treated as an exhibit as it may be scrutinized by a court of law.

8.3.4 Establish Common Approach Path (CAP)

i. to be established in all cases of homicide wherever possible;

ii. to run from the outer cordon through to the scene and all authorised personnel should use that specific route;

iii. avoid the likely route used by the perpetrator; and

iv. avoid the "last place seen" for kidnapped or missing persons.

8.3.5 Take additional steps to protect fragile evidence that may be damaged by weather condition, animal interference etc., by utilizing improvised covers.

8.3.6 Establish Rendezvous Point (RVP)

i. an area at the outer cordon and its location communicated to PECC; and

ii. all personnel should report their arrival to PECC.

8.4 Collection of Evidence and Scene of Crime Response

For the effective collection of evidence, the following shall apply:

8.4.1 PECC shall notify and request Forensic Crime Scene Investigator (FCSI) or Scene of Crime Officer (SOCO) to attend the scene at the earliest opportunity;

8.4.2 in cases of homicide and unnatural death, at least two FCSI/SOCO must attend the scene, one of whom should be a supervisory officer considered as the Forensic Crime Scene Manager (FCSM);

- 8.4.3** FCSI/SOCO should wear protective clothing to prevent/reduce contamination throughout their activities and for their safety;
- 8.4.4** The SOCO initial assessment of the scene should confirm that:
 - 8.4.4.1** the scene has been properly identified. Ideally there should be an inner and outer cordon but it is recognised that this is not always feasible;
 - 8.4.4.2** there is sufficient personnel to guard and protect the scene, control the public and maintain the Crime Scene log;
 - 8.4.4.3** they receive a full briefing from the RO to ascertain who has entered the scene and what their actions have been taken, how many scenes are believed to be involved in the incident. E.g. vehicles, victims, addresses etc.; and
 - 8.4.4.4** the RO is briefed and understand their responsibilities as specified in the Crime Scene log the CAP is situated appropriately.
- 8.4.5** The FCSI/SOCO will have charge of the scene to conduct the following:
 - 8.4.5.1** take photographs while being mindful of the need to preserve exhibits and contact evidence on the ground i.e. footprints. The utilisation of electrostatic lifting apparatus (ESLA) and casting should be considered prior to FCSI/SOCO walking into the scene;
 - 8.4.5.2** photograph the scene prior to any forensic examination;
 - 8.4.5.3** commence sketch plans before the start of any forensic examination;
 - 8.4.5.4** search the CAP first for exhibits and declare same cleared to facilitate entry to the scene by authorised persons;
 - 8.4.5.5** video all scenes after photography commence in homicide cases whenever possible;
 - 8.4.5.6** evaluate the evidence and interpret the secured scene based on the facts they observed or developed;
 - 8.4.5.7** liaise with the Investigating Officer at the scene to facilitate the investigative process, in case there is a need for extended searches to take place and the involvement of other agencies such as the Caribbean Search Centre.
- 8.4.6** FCSI/SOCO must assess the scene to ascertain the major features such as: cadaver (deceased person), weapon, instrument, footprint etc. Consideration must be given to weather and lighting condition as this may affect the sequence of evidence collection;
- 8.4.7** The retrieval of evidence should be carried out in a systematic way. Thorough examinations should be conducted of the entire scene, not just where the body was located in cases of homicide and unnatural death.
 - 8.4.7.1** The FCSI/SOCO will consider whether a pathologist is called out to the scene and in such cases this will be after consultation with the Investigating Officer;

- 8.4.8** Exhibits found/recovered at a crime scene, should firstly be examined by the FCSI/SOCO who will then decide whether they shall be fully processed at the scene or elsewhere.
- 8.4.9** Visible marks should be photographed and/or lifted as well as marks developed from chemically treated surfaces. Elimination fingerprints and shoe marks should be obtained after liaison with the Investigating Officer;
- 8.4.10** The FCSM must anticipate and seek where applicable, the victim's vehicle, place of work and accommodation, to ensure its protection at an early stage. If a suspected perpetrator has been detained, similar scenes will have to be considered;
- 8.4.11** Unless exigent circumstances exist or authorization of the Senior Officer, the RO or Scene Control Officer at major crime scenes shall not engage upon the collection of potential evidential value;
- 8.4.12** In many cases it has proved to be beneficial for the investigating officer to re-visit and also briefly search the scene at the conclusion of the SOCO search. By utilising the different disciplines within the Jamaica Constabulary, this will ensure that the maximum amount of evidence will then have been recovered.
- 8.4.13 Treating with Body**
- 8.4.13.1 Ideally, a qualified medical practitioner should attend in order to confirm that life is extinct. However, they should not move the body more than is absolutely necessary.
- 8.4.13.2 It would also be recommended good practice if, at this stage a pathologist could attend the scene to view the victim in situation and take the necessary temperature and swabs from the body, of particular importance for decomposing bodies.
- 8.4.13.3 Fragile evidence around the body should be collected prior to the body being moved, i.e. blood distribution, footwear impressions and drag marks.
- 8.4.13.4 The funeral directors should be requested to attend, however they should not be contacted immediately upon FCSI/SOCO arrival, as there is work to be completed before the cadaver can be moved.
- 8.4.13.5 If the cadaver is naked, consideration should be given to taping it for hairs and fibres.
- 8.4.13.6 In order to reduce contamination of the scene, where possible the funeral directors should not enter the homicide scene but the wrapped body taken out from the scene to them. However it is recognised that this may not always be practicable.
- 8.4.13.7 The police MUST escort the funeral director with the body to the mortuary in order for the continuity of the body to be preserved. This should be the 1st Responder or another officer who arrived at the same time and not the FCSI/SOC personnel. See precedence (*BISH nexus (1978) 16 JLR 106 (CA)*)

8.4.14 Swabbing

All persons involved in shootings must be swabbed. This must be carried out by a qualified officer from Scenes of Crime Unit, Institute of Forensic Science and Legal Medicine (IFSLM), or from the adjoining divisions.

- i. Swab hands before the body is removed. It is of utmost importance to eliminate/reduce contamination of gunshot residue as far as practicable
- ii. If hand swabbing for gunshot residue is to take place at a later time, the hands, head and feet should be bagged with paper bags.
- iii. It should then be wrapped by the FCSI/SOCOs into a body sheet or body bag.

8.5 Closing of the Crime Scene

At the conclusion of the crime scene examination, the following must be undertaken:

- 8.5.1 the FCSM and the Investigator Officer should inspect the scene to ensure that everything has been processed;
- 8.5.2 any damage caused throughout the search/examination should be recorded and photographed to prevent malicious civil litigation claims;
- 8.5.3 the FCSI/SOCO must handover all securely packaged and labelled exhibits to the investigating officer or to the local exhibits store against a receipt. The Investigating Officer must be able to account for all exhibits relating to their investigation;
- 8.5.4 a FCSI/SOCO report/worksheet (SOC2) will be completed for every scene of crime in duplicate and a copy forwarded to the Investigating Officer at the earliest opportunity for their information and inclusion in the investigation file;
- 8.5.5 the ultimate responsibility of handing over the scene to the owner MUST be done by the Officer in-charge of Criminal Investigation; and
- 8.5.6 the FCSI/SOCO will complete his/her report including details of all exhibits found/recovered as well as those submitted to the IFSLM and by whom received.

8.6 Work Instructions

The following procedures must be strictly adhered to in the processing of all crime scenes:

8.6.1 Sketch Plans

Sketch Plans must be done of all crime scenes in accordance to the following:

- i. Measurements should be included on any sketch and triangulation of measurements with an appropriate key is advocated for the accurate plotting of exhibits.
- ii. If these plans are not drawn to scale, then they should be annotated with;
 - a) 'not to scale',
 - b) a directional arrow, and
 - c) signature, name and rank of the officer completing the sketch.

8.6.2 Control Access

- 8.6.2.1 Restrict all persons, irrespective of rank from entering the inner cordon of the crime scene unless they are specifically authorised by the Forensic Crime Scene Manager (FCSM).
- 8.6.2.2 All persons entering the crime scene will be required to provide identification.
- 8.6.2.3 If any person enters a scene without permission, the details must be recorded in the Crime Scene log AND his/her clothes and footwear submitted for forensic examination and standards such as Hair, DNA and Major Case Prints for elimination purposes.
- 8.6.2.4 Unauthorised person entering the crime scene will be required to provide a written statement of evidence as to the purpose of his/her visit and submit his/her clothes for forensic examination.
- 8.6.2.5 Media representatives should be treated politely but firmly, referred to Corporate Communication Unit (CCU) and refused entry into any Crime Scene. They must remain outside the outer cordon at all times. No entry is permitted for the media at any stage of the investigation.

8.6.3 Photographs

The photographs should include the following:

- 8.6.3.1 The route to and from the scene by the offender
- 8.6.3.2 The outside area and grounds of the scene
- 8.6.3.3 Each room in cases of buildings
- 8.6.3.4 The cadaver from all directions, if possible,
- 8.6.3.5 Any particularly relevant exhibits,
- 8.6.3.6 Forensic evidence such as blood distribution and patterns, ballistic damage, footwear and tyre impressions etc.
- 8.6.3.7 Visible marks on bodies,
- 8.6.3.8 Damages caused as a result of searches/examination of the scene.
- 8.6.3.9 The area underneath the body after it has been removed.

8.6.4 FCSI/SOCO report/worksheet

The FCSI/SOCO report/worksheet should contain:

- 8.6.4.1 Time, date, location of offence /Scene of Crime examination number
- 8.6.4.2 Any relevant weather or situational conditions at the scene to include the status at the crime scene upon arrival (e.g. fire, crowds, and initial observations)
- 8.6.4.3 Factual detail and observations regarding the victim and inner scene e.g. injuries, lighting, signs of disturbance etc. Crime scene checklists (SOC 3) may facilitate this process, if utilised.

8.6.4.4 List of all evidential exhibits seized, their description and location found.

8.6.4.5 Viewer CD of photo images taken.

9.0 Legislative Authority/Guiding Principles

This standard operating procedure on major crime scene shall be read in conjunction with the following:

- [Jamaica Constabulary Force Act](#)
- Book of Rules
- Force Standing Orders, Chapters 25, 43, 47, 48 & 49 (& as amended)
- CIB Manual

10.0 Relevant Records and Forms

The following records must be completed or updated:

- Scene Attendance Register, Instruction for completion
- Scene Attendance Register – Appendix 1
- 1st Responding Officers Form SOC 1A – Appendix 2
- SOCO/FSCI Report – Appendix 3
- Crime Scene Log (Prior To Cordon) - Appendix 4
- Crime Scene Log (Prior To Cordon) - Appendix 5
- Crime Scene Narrative Report
- Laboratory Submission Form
- Exhibit Receipt

11.0 Roles and Function

The following outlines the specific roles and functions:

11.1 1st Responding Officer (RO) /Scene Control Officer shall:

- 11.1.1 provide initial response to, assess and preserve the crime scene.
- 11.1.2 maintain chain of custody of exhibits until handed over to the investigating Officer.

11.2 The Forensic Crime Scene Officers/Investigators shall:

- 11.2.1 assess and respond to requests for forensic support
- 11.2.2 process/examine primary and secondary crime scene(s)
- 11.2.3 ensure thorough evidence collection and documentation of items collected
- 11.2.4 provide for the security, preservation and safe transportation of forensic evidence

Appendix 1

JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

Scene Attendance Register - Instructions for Completion

1. The register is the record of entry to the crime scene and may be thoroughly scrutinized by a court of law at a later date. Hence, it must be treated as an exhibit from the outset.
2. The register must be started at the first opportunity by the 1st Responding Officer (RO) who must insert his or her details below.
3. The RO or Scene Control Officer must record the details of all persons who are in some way connected with the scene, to include the police prior to the implementation of the cordon. When the cordon has been implemented the log will record the details of all authorised persons who are entering the crime scene, noting also, their time of arrival and departure and reason for entry.
4. Entry to the scene must be refused unless authorised by the FCSM. Ask persons for their identification and details of their authorization. Be polite but firm and deny access to unauthorised person irrespective their rank. Where entry has been refused to a person or a person enters the crime scene without permission, the details must be recorded. Consult with your supervisor where necessary.
5. If individual officers cannot be identified, then a record of the unit, call sign or vehicle's identification should be noted.
6. On handing over the post of RO to a Scene Control Officer, sign your name under your last entry on the register. Draw a line across the page, directly beneath your signature. The succeeding Scene Control Officer will continue the register directly beneath this line. They will update the register with their details below for continuity purposes.

The register will be maintained until the scene is released. It must then be submitted to the investigating officer, along with the RO or scene Control Officer's statement.

Appendix 2

1st RESPONDING OFFICERS



SOC 1A

[illegible]

Appendix 3



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE
FORENSIC CRIME SCENE INVESTIGATORS REPORT

Station Tel. No.....

Crime Register #.....

Investigating Officer.....

Call Out Reference No.....

Division.....

Station.....

Name & Reg. FCSI.....

Offence.....

Date...../...../.....

Time.....

Location.....

Date & Time of Arrival.....

Victim.....

Address.....

D.O.B.....

Occupation.....

Clothing Worn.....

Suspect.....

Address.....

D.O.B.....

Occupation.....

Clothing Worn.....

Crime Scene Sketch

Particulars of Exhibit

Chemistry

G.S.R Accused

G.S.R Suspect

G.S.R Deceased

Narcotics Victim

Toxicology

Paint

Soil

Glass

Arson

Other.....

Biology

Blood

Stain

Hair

Saliva

Semen

Clothing

Fibre

Finger

Nail

Clipping

Other.....

Ballistic

Type

of

Firearm

Serial No.....

From Weapon: Total number of Bullets

Brand & Number of Casing(s).....

From Scene: Total number of Cartridges.....

Brand & Number of Casing(s).....

Total number of Bullets (warhead)

Total number of Bullet Fragments

Impression

Foot

Shoe

Tire

Tool mark

Bite Mark

Finger Print

Latent Print

Deceased Print

Suspect Print

Elimination

Print

Date & Time of Departure.....

Quality Checked By.....



SOC 1B

[illegible]

Appendix 5



CRIME SCENE LOG (AFTER CORDON)

SOC 1

Persons attending the scene